CHAPTER 05 / PROGRESSION

Progressive overload

Small steps. Meaningful change.

Make progress without chasing a heavier number every day.

How to use this guide

Read the explanations, try the practical examples and complete the worksheet. All training logs and menus are illustrative. Use the website for interactive tools; this document remains useful offline.

01	02	03
Understand	Put into practice	Review

Scope and safety

General education for adults, not a medical diagnosis, personalized treatment or a guaranteed transformation. Stop exercise for sharp pain or unusual symptoms. A qualified clinician, dietitian or coach can help when individual circumstances require assessment.

What you will learn

01. Progress has more than one form
02. Use double progression
03. Manage fatigue
04. Read the timeline honestly

01 / Progress has more than one form

Progressive overload means adjusting the training demand as your capacity develops. You can add controlled repetitions, increase load, improve usable range or add appropriate work. A heavier weight with a shortened or uncontrolled movement is not automatically progress.

PUT IT INTO PRACTICE: Compare similar technique and range of motion.

02 / Use double progression

Pick a rep range, such as eight to twelve. Keep the load while gradually earning more controlled repetitions. Once all intended sets reach the upper end at the intended effort, try a small load increase and return toward the lower end. This is an example method, not a mandatory schedule.

PUT IT INTO PRACTICE: Example: 10, 10, 9 can become 11, 10, 10 before the load changes.

03 / Manage fatigue

Performance fluctuates with sleep, stress, travel and illness. A plateau across several comparable sessions invites a review, not punishment. A deload is a temporary reduction in training demand. Its timing should reflect fatigue and context rather than a universal calendar.

PUT IT INTO PRACTICE: If several lifts decline while sleep worsens, first review recovery and workload.

04 / Read the timeline honestly

The month slider demonstrates a fictional training story. The mannequin changes symbolically; it does not predict your body. Actual strength and muscle gain vary, and progress may include periods of maintenance.

PUT IT INTO PRACTICE: Use your training journal to compare your real sessions.

Practical reference

Example training week

An editable beginner example; start with manageable loads and comfortable range. This is not a personalized prescription.

Day	Movements	Example work
Monday	Goblet squat, push-up, cable row	2 sets each; controlled reps
Wednesday	Romanian deadlift, pulldown, shoulder press	2 sets each; controlled reps
Friday	Split squat, dumbbell press, row	2 sets each; controlled reps
Other days	Rest or comfortable light activity	Adjust to recovery

Example double progression

Session	Load	Repetitions	Decision
A	10 kg	10 / 10 / 9	Practice at same load
B	10 kg	11 / 10 / 10	Keep technique consistent
C	10 kg	12 / 12 / 12	Consider smallest load increase
D	Next suitable load	Return toward 8 reps	Review effort and control

These sessions are fictional and have no promised dates. Progression should follow readiness rather than an obligation to lift more every workout.

Your study worksheet

Knowledge check

When should you increase the load in a double-progression example?

A. Every day

B. After meeting the rep and technique goal

C. Whenever you feel sore

Reflect and apply

Prompt	Your response
One idea I can explain in my own words	
One action I can try this week	
What I will observe or measure	
What would make me seek professional guidance	
My next review date	

Chapter summary

Progress the demand when you are ready, while protecting movement quality and recovery.

Answer and explanation

B. Earn the intended repetitions with consistent technique before adding a manageable amount.

Sources & limitations

These sources inform the educational principles. Original examples and planning templates are not study findings. No institution listed below endorses this journal. References checked November 2026.

ACSM (2026) — Resistance training prescription: overview of reviews

https://pubmed.ncbi.nlm.nih.gov/41843416/

Interpretation matters

Research describes groups under particular conditions. Individual responses vary. The website models are simplified illustrations, not precise physiological simulations. Food values and calorie estimates are approximate. Use consistent observation and individualized professional support when needed.